

Family experiences navigating services in San Diego County

Bloom Works

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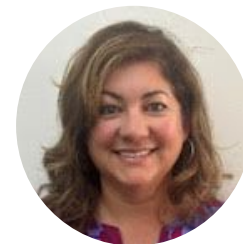


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Agenda

- Intro
- What we learned
 - Mapping San Diego's community pathways
 - Understanding families and their needs
- Recommendations

San Diego County Office of Child and Family Strengthening



LIVE WELL
SAN DIEGO

Project goals

- Understand the experiences and needs of families who have been referred to warmlines or otherwise accessed supports, social services, benefits, or community programs
- Identify where family needs are being met and where they're not
- Recommend priority areas for child welfare agencies to improve family experiences searching for and receiving help

What we learned

Mapping San Diego's Community Pathways

Simplified community pathways map



Call made to warmline or hotline



Services & Resources

Reporter pathway



Mandated reporter
calls to report concern

Community
Response Guides

CPS Hotline
Response

Child and Family
Wellbeing Candidacy
Assessments

Family
Connection Hub

School
partners

CPS
services

Evidence
Based
Practices

Concrete
supports

Services
or
Resources

- Oral/dental health
- Healthy development services
- First steps family support
- Child care resources
- Home visiting program

Family pathway



Parent calls for help

211

First 5 Warmline

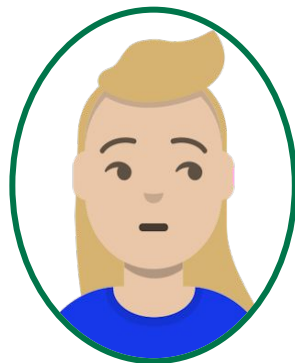
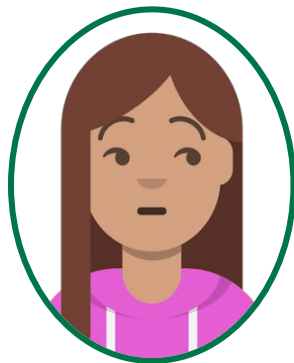
Government agencies' role in "prevention" is unclear

- San Diego's culture shift to support families before child welfare involvement is needed, but is not yet visible to families
- Families value earlier engagement from government agencies
- Communication, service, and knowledge sharing is inconsistent
- Government agencies aren't often visible or accessible where families frequent

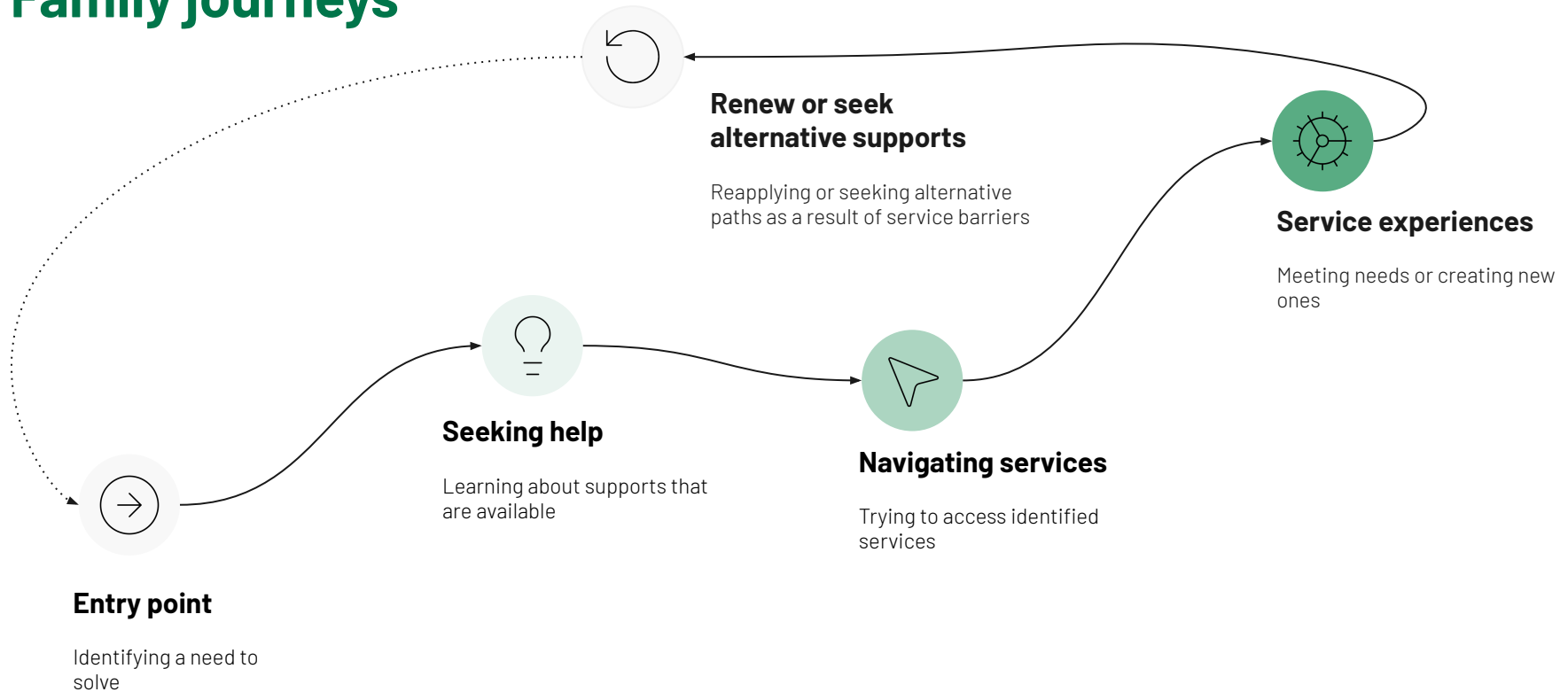
Understanding families and their needs

What is a persona?

- A composite, not a real person
- Helps us understand needs, goals, and barriers
- Personas are helpful to clarify diverse experiences and design for different needs



Family journeys





Selena

Struggling to rebuild

About:

- 40's
- Separated
- Lives in shelter
- 2 teen children
- Has a disability
- Immigrant with limited English

"When you suffer domestic violence, you don't just suffer physical and emotional violence, you suffer economic violence too."

Goal: Provide a safe and stable space for her children, so they can heal, study to better themselves, and get ahead in life.

Navigation style:

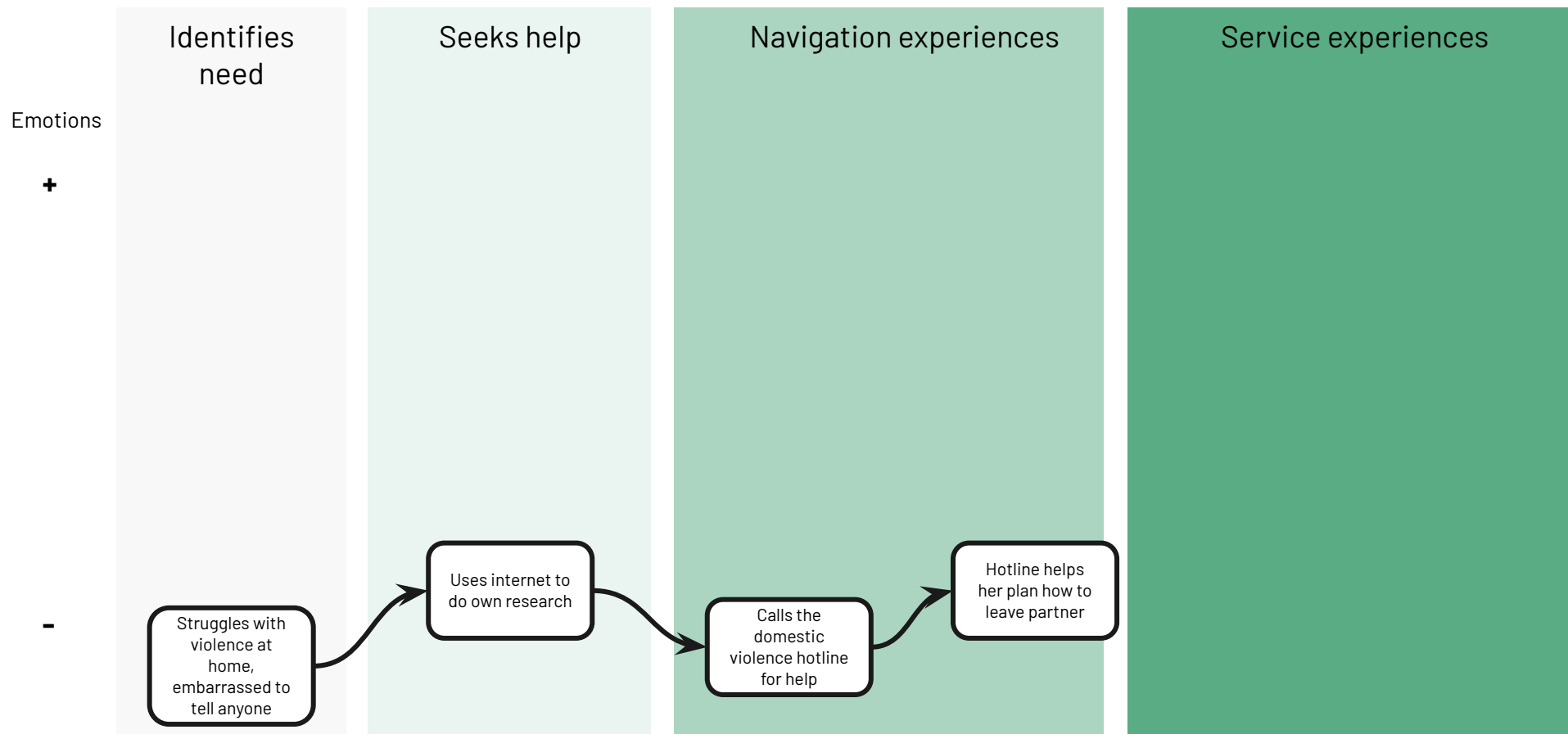
- Called a domestic violence hotline to get immediate help, felt embarrassed
- Uses internet to do own research
- Leans on shelter and domestic violence programs to learn about food and financial assistance for her family

Barriers:

- Limited support from family and friends
- Fears and safety concerns about ex-partner
- Experienced challenges to leave shelter and secure long-term housing

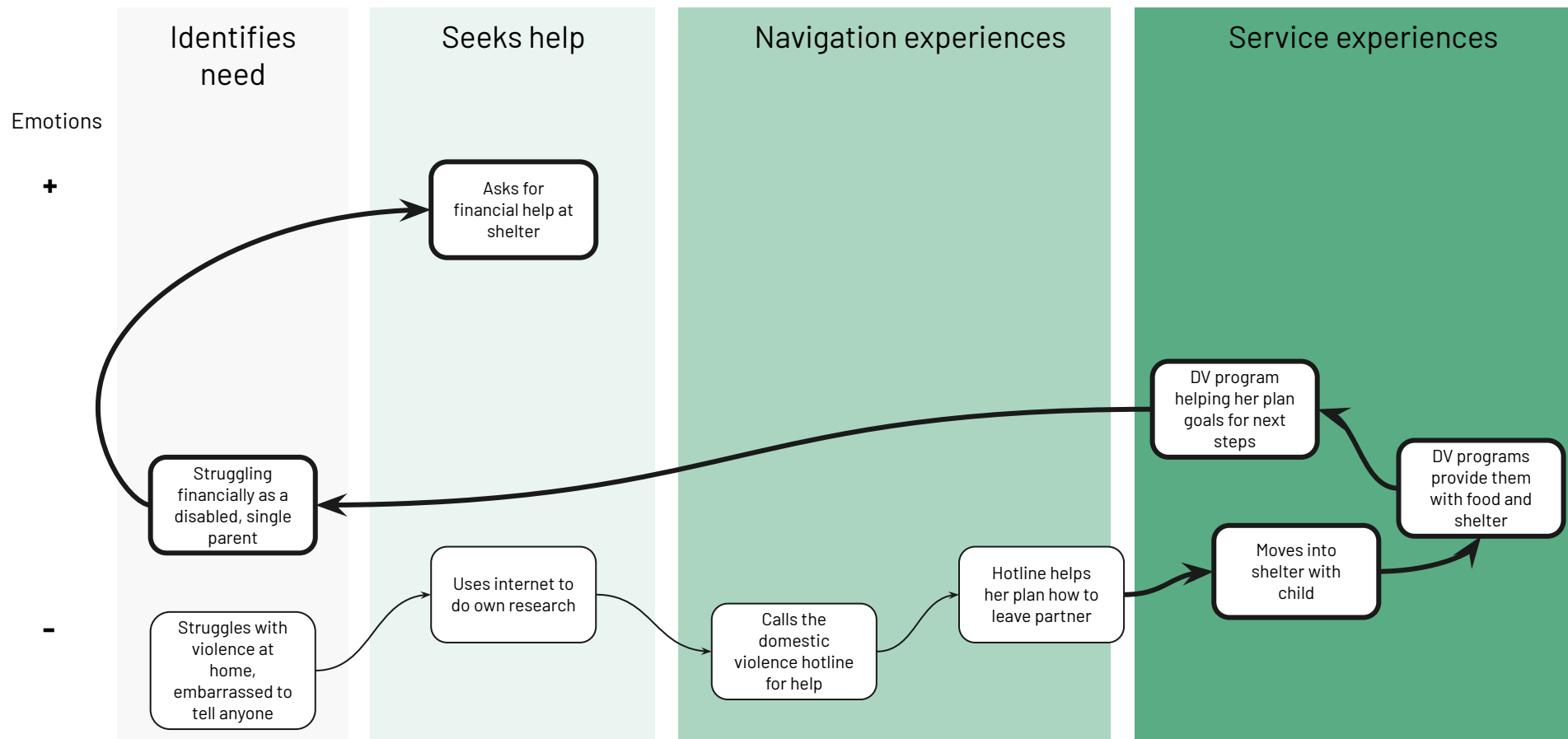


Selena: *Struggling to rebuild*



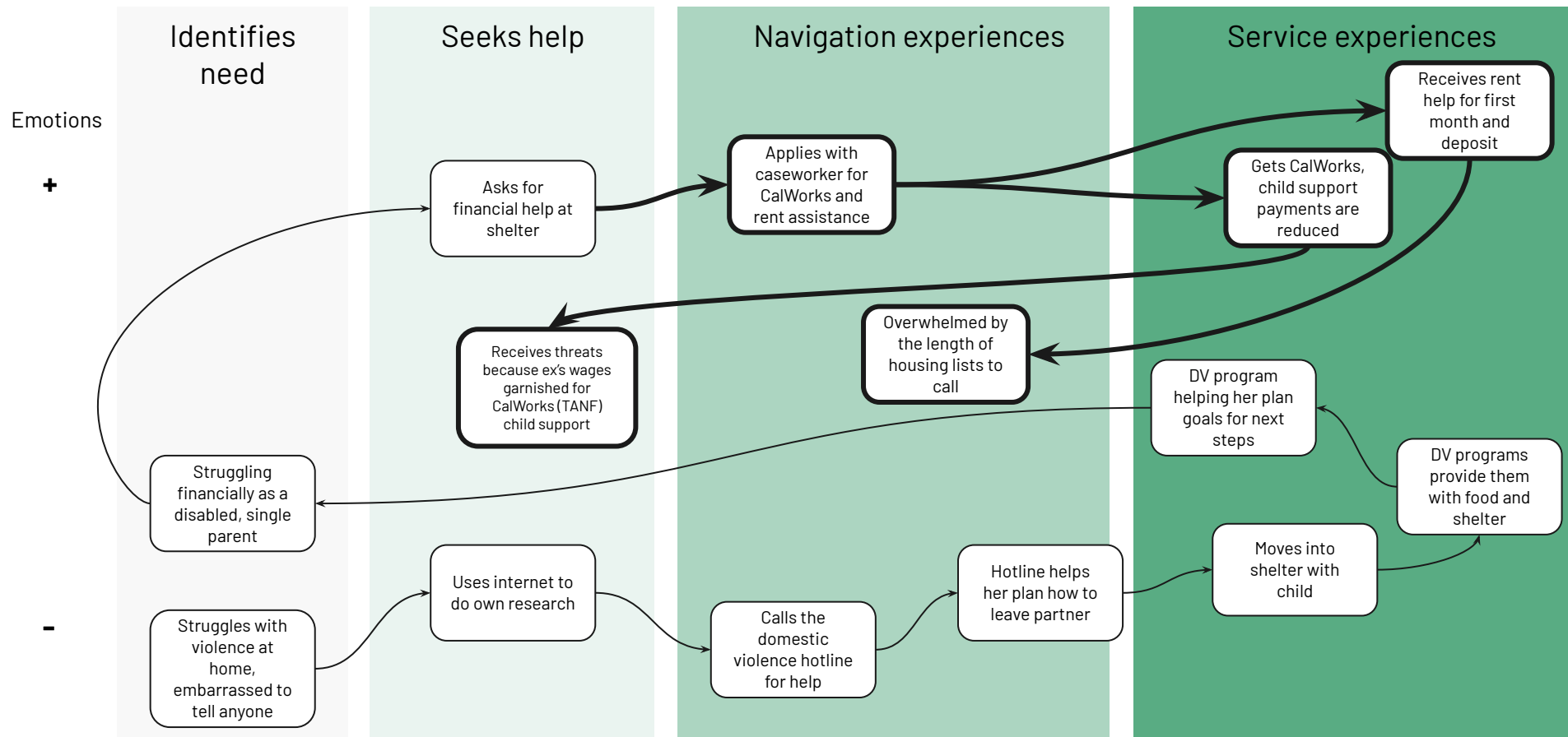


Selena: *Struggling to rebuild*





Selena: Struggling to rebuild



Family journeys

- Parents are taking the lead in their service navigation journeys
- Journeys are layered and winding
- Access to one service opens up doors to another
- Service barriers compound parents' struggles



Valentina

Supporting her children to thrive

About:

- 40's
- Married
- Stably housed
- 2 children under 6
- 3 year old has autism and ADHD
- Immigrant
- Monolingual Spanish speaker

"I only knew about speech therapy. Lots of kids get speech therapy. But the occupational part was eye opening, what they do what they teach. Like you see them playing but its way deeper than that."

Goal: Ensure child has uninterrupted therapy so they are equitably supported to thrive.

Navigation style:

- Takes children to routine medical appointments, but not always for herself.
- Doctor diagnosed youngest with autism/ADHD and referred them to a community organization offering developmental services.
- Developmental services provided information on financial aid.
- Asks at church to learn about additional financial help.

Barriers:

- Limited public transit and struggles to pay for cost of ride sharing apps to her children's appointments.
- 3 year old is aging out of services, waiting on referral to new program.
- Caseworker turnover and challenges navigating English language phone menus to reach the right person.



Cheyenne

Helping professional need support

About:

- 30's
- Single
- Lives with parents
- Has 1 child
- Support specialist at a community organization
- Has a disability

"One day after work was thinking about that, and struggling with [the] same thing. I am helping a lot of people to apply for programs, what if I apply?"

Goal: Wants to have their own needs met as they help meet other people's needs.

Navigation style:

- Always researching services and programs in her role.
- Receives emails from other agencies about resources.
- Spoke to someone who encouraged her to apply for a affordable housing; felt more empowered to apply after conversation.

Barriers:

- Section 8 funding cuts and waitlist freezes are hurting clients.
- Enhanced care manager hasn't follow-up on her medical care navigation.
- Believes it might be a conflict of interest for her to look for help because of her role.
- Got approved for rental assistance, but still can't find housing.



Chelsea

Reuniting with children

About:

- 30's
- Single
- Formerly incarcerated
- Has 2 children in foster care; reunifying
- In transitional housing
- LGBTQ2SIA+
- Has a disability

"Now that I have to call them [211] to find out [info] because I have to leave here [soon] and my car doesn't have license plates - [that's] where we are going to sleep."

Goal: Move forward from CPS involvement and incarceration to create a new, stable life for herself and children.

Navigation style:

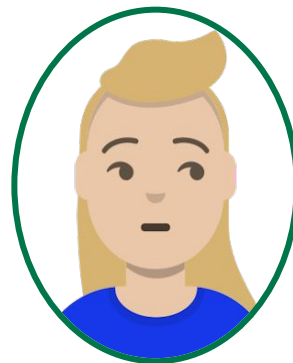
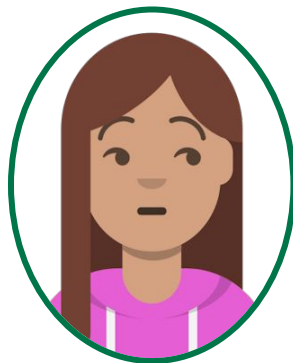
- Self-educated navigator, strong advocate for herself and others.
- Leans on parents with similar experiences of child welfare system involvement.

Barriers:

- Reintegrating back into society after incarceration and reuniting with children.
- Rude interactions with social service professionals.
- Seeking employment and housing with a criminal record and low credit score.
- Rejected for SSI.
- Finding outdated housing lists online.

Personas are not exhaustive

- Personas only reflect the families we spoke with
- Some families aren't represented because they only reflect a singular experience in our research
- There are potential clusters that we didn't reach in our research



Parent personas

We would like to acknowledge participant types that didn't turn into a persona since they appeared once in our research

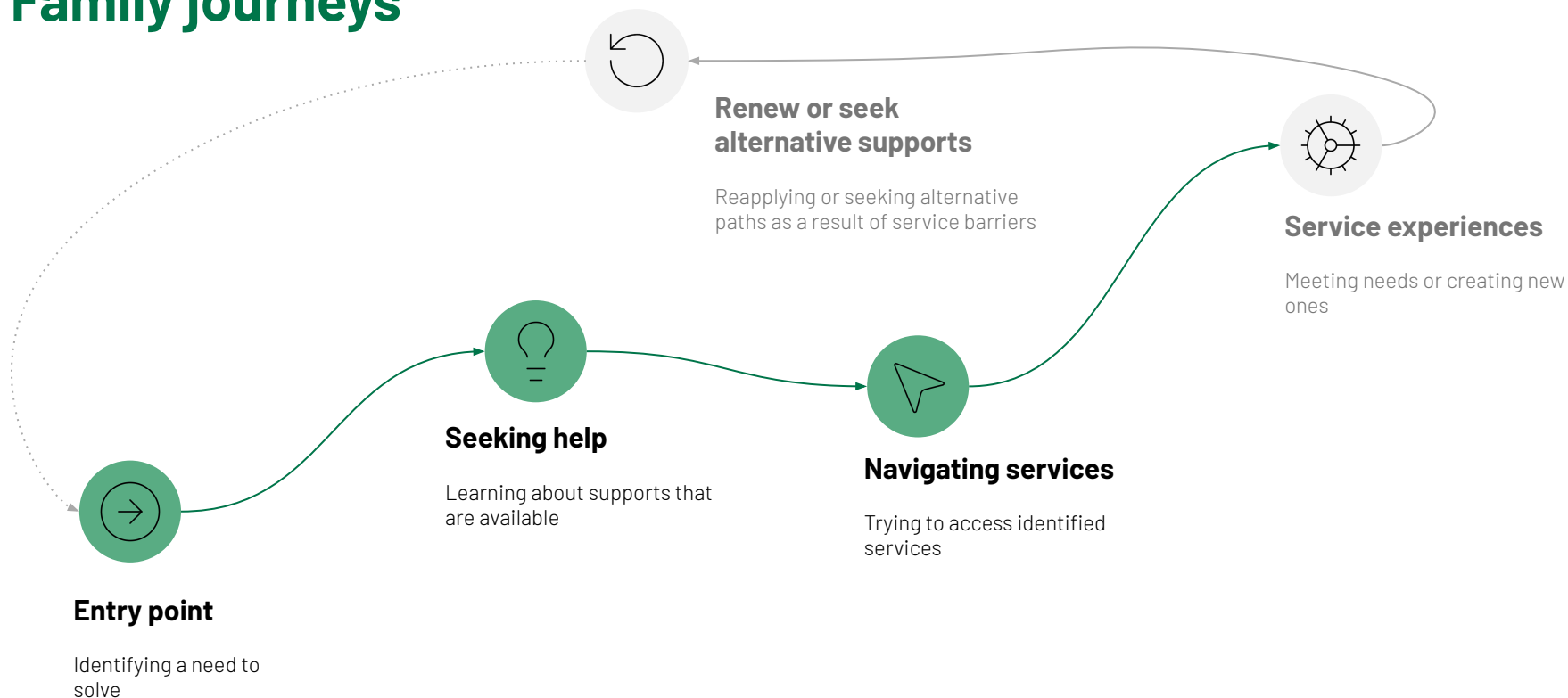
- Single father with disabilities who is working to provide for his children
- Mother who didn't look for help until offered them at hospital, and later with CPS



How families seek out and navigate supports

- How are families learning about supports?
- What is most helpful? Less helpful?

Family journeys



Asking for help is hard for families

- Families lack a clear, trusted place, person, or agency to turn to for help
- Instead, families search online or ask for help from service providers
- Families put in time and effort to search, but don't find what they're looking for

How families learn about supports



Word of mouth
from family and
friends



Flyers



Social media



**Government
entities**
like WIC and school



211



**Community
organizations**
like SAY San Diego



Medical facilities
such as doctor's
offices and hospitals



**Their place of
employment**



Places of worship

Helpful sources of navigation



Caseworkers are *valued when:*

- Knowledgeable and well connected
- Advocates and care coordinators
- Direct source of answers
- Highly responsive
- Non-judgemental and empathetic



Health facilities and schools are *best when:*

- Offer assessments, referrals, and information
- Experienced with the resource they refer families to
- Are trusted professionals families have a relationship with

Challenges with navigation



Outdated information,
including services or
resources that:

- no longer exist
- don't accept new applicants
- have long waitlists



Too much information,
including:

- too many flyers
- long resource lists to contact and follow-up with



Cold outreach, doesn't
always reach families
because:

- phone numbers are unlisted
- they no longer want assistance

Families have mixed experiences with 211

211 is *helpful* because:

- It has a strong brand, most families are already aware of it
- It's a starting point for connecting to resources, like food pantries
- Coordinated entry facilitates access to emergency shelter and creates a record of families' needs and services accessed

211 is *challenging* to use when:

- It passes callers to other numbers, creating follow-up work for families
- Information provided is outdated or it's unclear who to contact
- Families face structural barriers like access to long-term housing



Once I called [211] asking for a list of medical providers and they sent me an empty list. They've done that 3 times. That to me was ridiculous. Someone must have looked at that letter to mail it to me and seen that there was nothing on the list. **They wrote a note acknowledging that the list was empty, but then why even send it?"**

- Parent



[I] know if there's anything I am looking for, I can just call 211.
211 knows everything. It's like Google but over the phone so
you don't have to type and do the research."

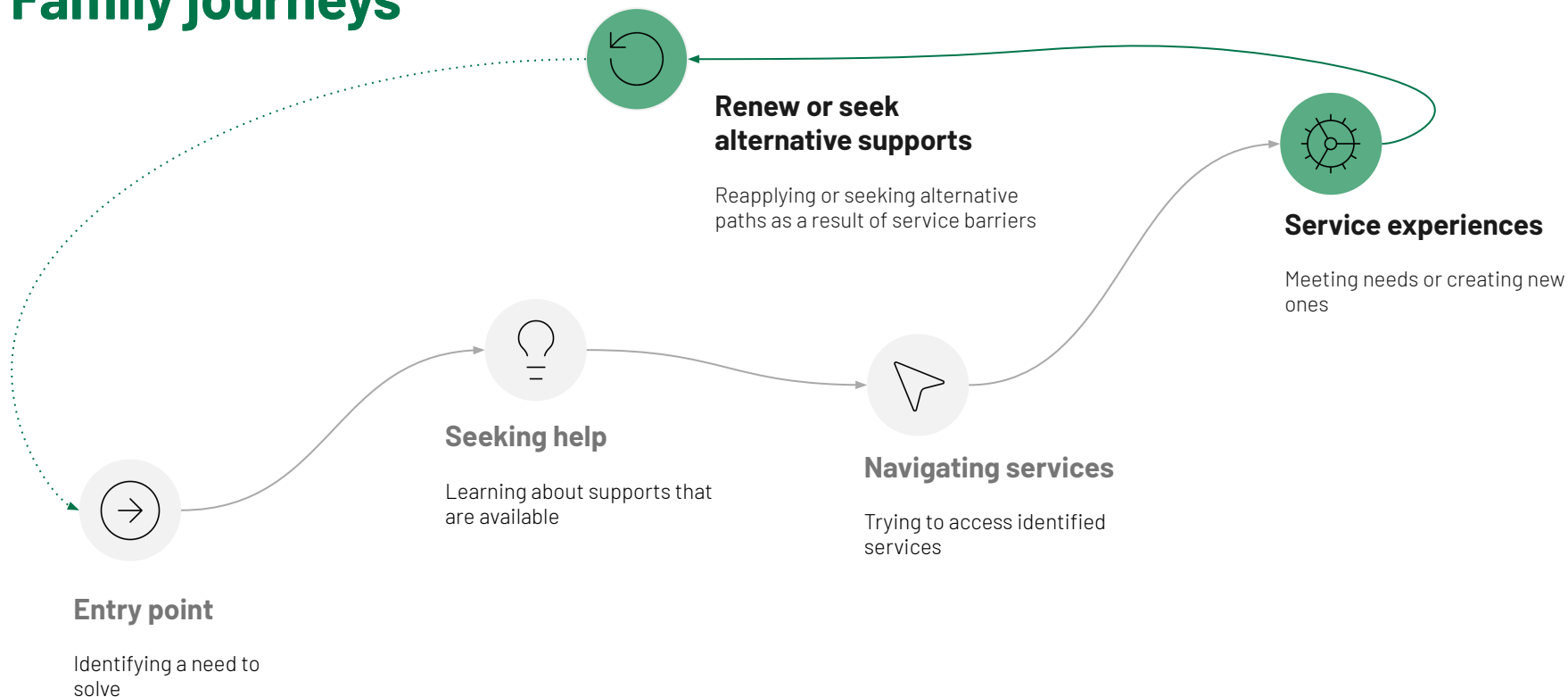


- Parent

What families need and the supports they access

- What supports are families leaning on and why?
- What are some of their unmet needs?

Family journeys



Families are served by a patchwork of supports



Housing

Most needed, but
hardest to access



Financial assistance

CalWorks (TANF) is
critical for families with
access to it



Food

WIC and CalFresh (SNAP)
alleviates grocery bills
and allows families to buy
healthy foods



MediCal

Medicaid is needed
especially for
children's health and
therapy coverage



It [food stamps] helps out, making her [daughter's] lunch, making her breakfast, having her snacks ready. It just helps a lot.

I can skip a meal or two. I don't care as long as my daughter is fed."

- Parent



They took away child support, \$525 check, and they only gave me half or less. **That was awful. It was the worst experience of my life.**



- Parent

Housing is critical

- Families are left on waitlists for years
- Shelter and transitional assistance only provides time-limited support
- Rental assistance is limited to those who can find a willing landlord
- Families need help searching for housing, especially for parents with criminal records, eviction records, or low credit scores

Government benefits are hard to access

- Excessive documentation requirements and long processing times
- Access to benefits is complicated by nearing or going over the income threshold
- Going in-person to county offices gets families a faster and more direct answer
- Previous application experience makes it easier to apply

All services have barriers to access

- Transportation costs to get to services add up quickly
- Long waiting lists and lack of follow-up, clarity and communication
- Lack of transparency in what is offered
- Inconsistent customer service experiences
- Eligibility requirements are unclear, and harder to demonstrate for families in crisis



I did get an offer from Section 8 for the project based housing. And then, what ended up happening is that since we're moving and moving and moving, **all of our credentials have gotten lost.**"



- Parent

Tailored navigation reduces burdens

- Provides direct answers and connections
- Advocates for families to connect to services
- Helps overcome barriers and negative service experiences
- Provides personal care and empathy that helps families feel seen and heard

Recommendations:

Reimagining support for
families in San Diego

Recommendations

Balance navigation with resource availability

- Match resources to family needs
- Facilitate specialized navigation

Improve access and delivery of benefits and services

- Make customer experience a priority
- Collaborate across government agencies
- Dedicate time and resources to housing services

Make it easier to look for help

- Be present in the community
- Use creative advertising strategies
- Contact families through multiple channels

Next steps

Progressive projects



Winter 2025



**Voluntary
services**

Spring 2025



**Understanding
warmlines**

Summer 2025



**Family
experiences**

Fall 2025



**Technical
assistance**

Develop a resource to support jurisdictions working to improve service navigation

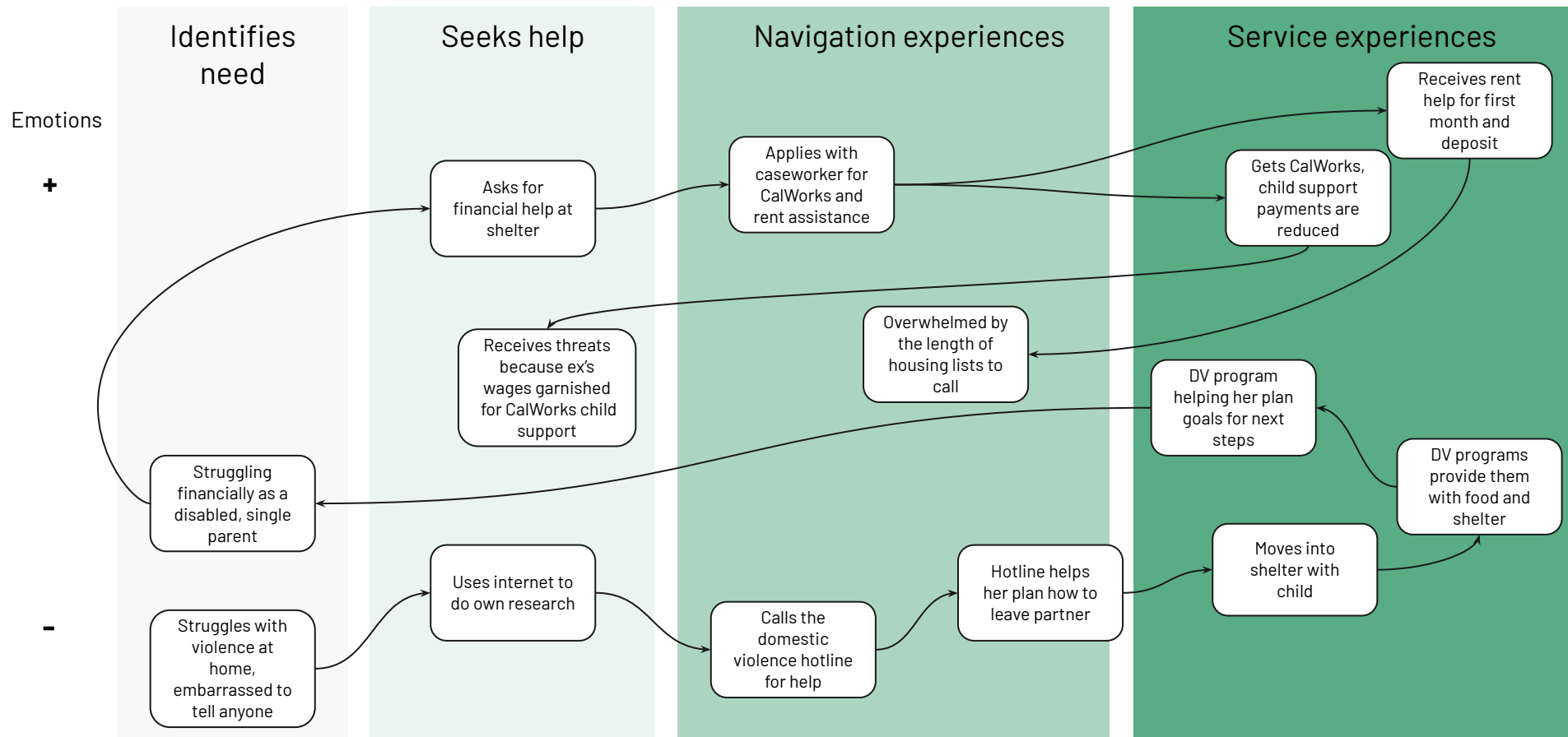
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prevention@bloomworks.digital

Appendix

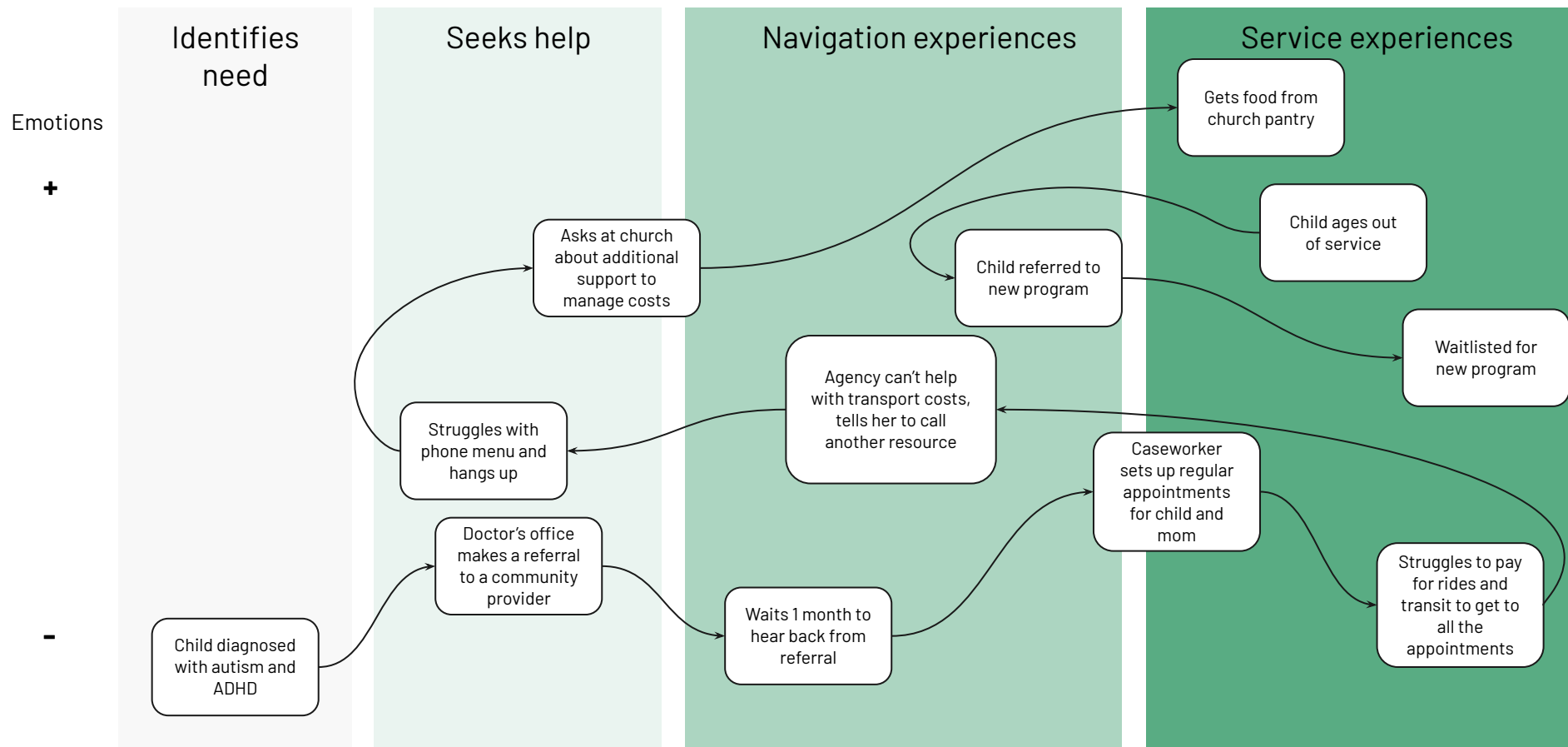


Selena: Struggling to rebuild



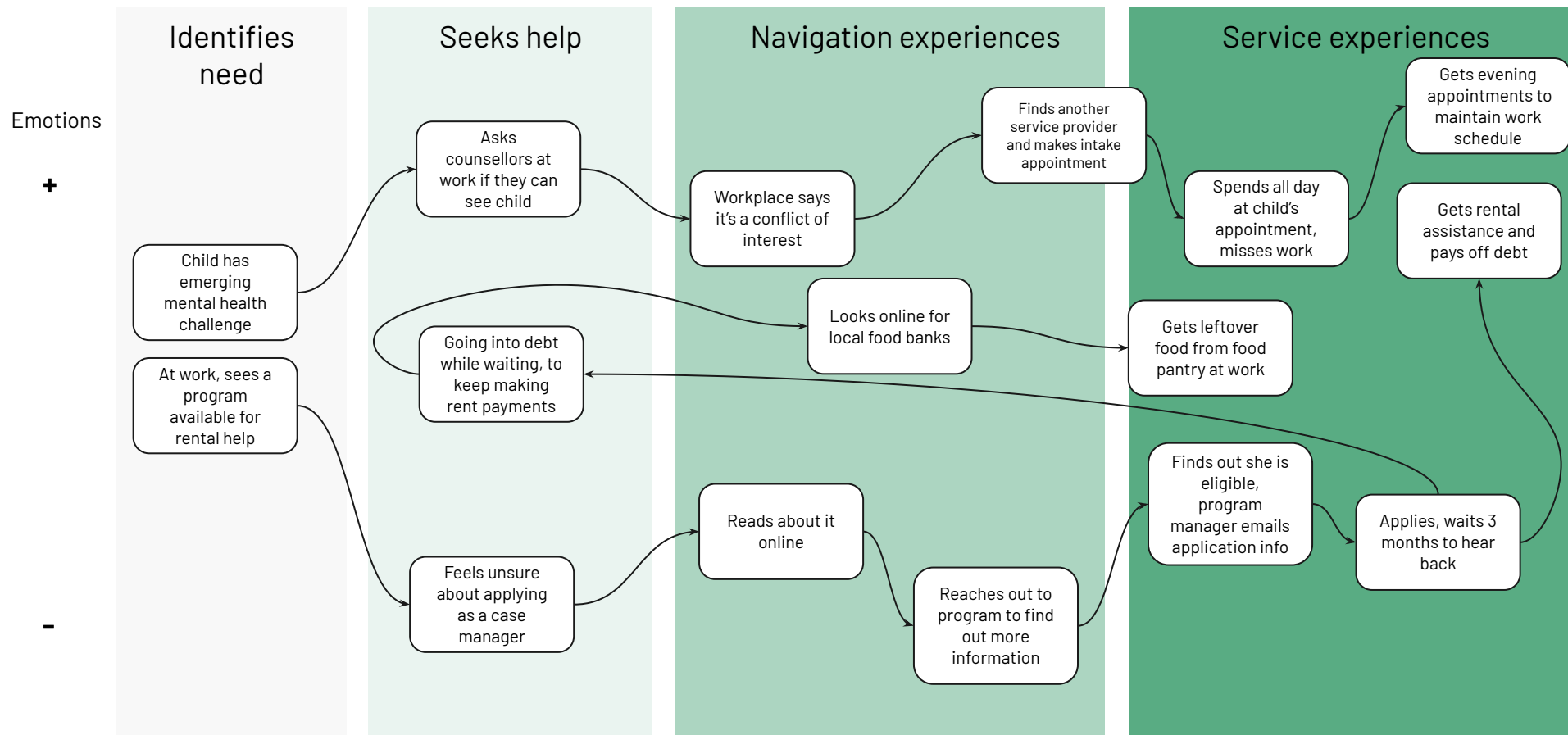


Valentina: *Supporting her children to thrive*





Cheyenne: *Helping professional needing support*





Chelsea: Reuniting with child

Emotions

+

-

Identifies need

Planned
probational
release from
incarceration

Seeks help

Starts reading
resources on
reuniting with
child

Navigation experiences

Gets connected
to transitional
housing
program

Asks CPS
worker about
parent partner
program

CPS worker isn't
sure about
program, gets
back to her

Service experiences

Moves into
transitional
housing

Connects with
parent partner

Transitional
housing
contract is
ending

Needs to move
out of housing
in 2 weeks

Asks parent
partner for help
with housing

Divides up tasks
of calling
housing lists

Worried about
having housing
in time, to
reunify

Calls 211 to get
license plates
updated to live
in her truck

Landlords don't
accept her
because of
record

